IIA • WEB DESIGN

Usability and Website Evaluation

UNIT 09 | RECOGNISE PROBLEMS • TEST USER TASKS • IMPROVE INFORMATION SERVICES

Library and Information Studies • Records Management Systems

Learning outcomes

At the end of this unit

- Explain usability and accessibility
- evaluate simple webpages
- record specific findings.

You will practise

- Compare two fictional information-service pages
- apply an eight-point checklist
- write three improvements.

KEY IDEA **Evaluation is about how well a visitor succeeds, not whether a site merely looks attractive.**

A visitor’s task matters more than decoration

Begin with a user task

- Visitors come with a purpose: locate a resource, read instructions, or submit an enquiry.

Why appearance is not enough

- A colourful library homepage is ineffective if a visitor cannot find the catalogue search.

KEY IDEA **Ask: Can an intended visitor complete the important task?**

Usability, user experience and accessibility

Usability

- Effectiveness, efficiency and satisfaction when particular
- people carry out tasks in context.

Related concepts

- UI: visible controls and layout.
- UX: wider user experience.
- Accessibility: inclusion of people with disabilities.

KEY IDEA **These concepts overlap but are not interchangeable.**

Five questions to ask about a website

Useful questions

- Can the visitor find the right information? Can
- they understand the labels and complete their task?

Quality checks

- Is navigation predictable? Is content readable? Can the page
- be used by keyboard and on a phone?

KEY IDEA **The strongest starting point is a visitor’s goal.**

Who is the intended visitor?

Know who visits

- Students, researchers, staff, and members of the
- public can have different needs and language.

Define the context

- Consider device, time pressure, familiarity with systems
- and whether the person needs accessibility support.

KEY IDEA **A good design is appropriate for its intended audience.**

Library visitor: find opening hours

Visitor

- A student travelling to campus wants to know when the college library closes.

Successful design

- Opening hours are visible under a clear label, readable on
- a phone, and not hidden inside an unrelated menu.

KEY IDEA **A test task should describe what success looks like.**

Records visitor: request public guidance

Visitor

- A member of the public wants to request an eligible public service report.

Successful design

- The website clearly explains eligibility, required steps and where
- to ask for help, without showing restricted records.

KEY IDEA **Usability and responsible information disclosure must work together.**

User tasks and realistic scenarios

User + task + context

- “A first-year student on a phone needs to
- find borrowing conditions before visiting the library.”

What to observe

- Record the path used, confusing labels, missing guidance and whether the answer was found.

KEY IDEA **Realistic scenarios are better than arbitrary design opinions.**

Seven principles of helpful web design

Principles 1–4

- Clarity: familiar words.
- Consistency: predictable menus.
- Visibility: main services prominent.

Principles 5–7

- Efficiency: fewer needless steps.
- Error recovery: helpful messages.
- Inclusiveness: different abilities and devices.

KEY IDEA **Use these as practical questions during page evaluation.**

Clear navigation and familiar words

Clear navigation

- A short menu uses familiar labels such as Home, Services, Catalogue and Contact.

Unclear navigation

- Menus labelled “TXR”, “Misc.” or internal reference codes make users guess where to go.

KEY IDEA **Name the destination or the task, not an internal office code.**

Information architecture and findability

Information architecture

- The organisation, grouping and labelling of website
- content so visitors can find information.

Application

- A library might group Catalogue, Borrowing Rules, Opening
- Hours and Ask a Librarian under understandable sections.

KEY IDEA **Information that is not findable is difficult to use.**

Good and poor navigation labels

Library: compare labels

- Less helpful: “LIS OPAC Services”.
- Clearer: “Search the Catalogue”.

Records: compare labels

- Less helpful: “RMD Form 17B”.
- Clearer: “Request a Public Record”.

KEY IDEA **Plain terms explain what visitors can expect.**

Visual hierarchy: what stands out first?

Visual hierarchy

- Use heading size, position, contrast and spacing to
- draw attention to the most important task.

Practical example

- On a library homepage, the catalogue search should
- stand out more than a long institutional-history paragraph.

KEY IDEA **Prominence should follow user importance, not decoration.**

Readable content and plain language

Readability

- Use plain sentences, meaningful headings, short paragraphs and a comfortable line length.

Common problems

- Tiny low-contrast text, too many decorative fonts
- and all-capital paragraphs make reading harder.

KEY IDEA **Writing and presentation both affect usability.**

Whitespace and consistent patterns

Whitespace

- Deliberate space separates sections, improves scanning
- and shows which items belong together.

Consistency

- Navigation position, button behaviour, spacing and
- typography should remain predictable across pages.

KEY IDEA **Consistent patterns reduce the effort of learning a site.**

Accessibility means more than visual design

Accessibility

- Websites should be usable by people with
- visual, hearing, motor and cognitive disabilities.

Practical checks

- Meaningful image text alternatives, labelled inputs, readable
- colours, keyboard access and predictable navigation.

KEY IDEA **Accessibility is essential for some visitors and improves experience for many others.**

WCAG: four guiding principles

Perceivable

- Information can be presented in forms users can perceive:
- text alternatives, clear presentation and captions where relevant.

Operable

- Essential actions must be keyboard-accessible, navigable
- and not dependent on mouse-only controls.

KEY IDEA **WCAG also includes Understandable and Robust.**

Keyboard access and visible focus

Keyboard test

- Press Tab through links and controls
- use Enter or Space to activate appropriate elements.

Visible focus

- The currently selected control should have an
- obvious outline or other visual focus indicator.

KEY IDEA **Try a page without using the mouse.**

Text alternatives and meaningful links

Text alternatives

- An informative picture needs appropriate alternative text
- a purely decorative one usually needs empty alt text.

Useful link text

- “Download Borrowing Rules (PDF)” says more than repeated “Click here” links.

KEY IDEA **Meaningful text supports scanning and assistive technology.**

Colour contrast, zoom and text size

Colour and contrast

- Important text must remain readable.
- Avoid pale text on similarly pale backgrounds.

Resize and zoom

- Test enlarged text and narrow screens
- important content should remain available without page-wide horizontal scrolling.

KEY IDEA **Visual accessibility should be checked, not assumed.**

Forms: labels, instructions and feedback

Clear labels

- Keep visible names for input fields and explain which details are required.

Helpful completion feedback

- Say “Enter an email in the format
- name@example.com”, rather than displaying only “Error 430”.

KEY IDEA **Good forms explain what to enter and what happens next.**

Error prevention and recovery

Prevent mistakes

- Ask only for necessary details, use sensible choices and warn before destructive actions.

Recover from mistakes

- Explain the problem beside the relevant field, preserve
- other entries and indicate how to continue.

KEY IDEA **Useful feedback saves the visitor time and confusion.**

Responsive usability on a phone

Check a phone layout

- Read text, follow the main menu, find the primary action and interact with form controls.

Watch for

- Page-wide sideways scrolling, tiny text, hidden sections, and buttons too close together.

KEY IDEA **Responsive styling is only valuable when the task remains usable.**

Simple website evaluation: six steps

1. Choose a real task

- Example: locate a library’s opening hours or records-centre public request guidance.

2–3. Define and attempt success

- Explain what counts as success, then try using
- the navigation a visitor would normally use.

KEY IDEA **Evaluation starts with a task before inspecting colours.**

Choose a realistic user task

Visitor task

- “Find the public records request procedure from the homepage.”

Success criterion

- The visitor can locate the correct publicly available guidance and understand the next step.

KEY IDEA **A clear criterion makes observations interpretable.**

Observe what happens and record evidence

Observe behaviour

- Write what actually happened: “The hours link was under About → Administration.”

Avoid vague opinions

- “The website is terrible” provides no location, evidence or way to fix the problem.

KEY IDEA **Record evidence, then propose a solution.**

Use an eight-point checklist

Eight beginner criteria

- Main task, navigation labels, heading structure and readable content.

Four more criteria

- Descriptive links, keyboard access, mobile layout and appropriate public information.

KEY IDEA **A short checklist guides attention; it is not a complete audit.**

Not every issue has equal impact

High priority

- An essential task is blocked: a request button is
- not keyboard-accessible or a main search function fails.

Medium vs low

- Medium: confusing menu requires extra steps.
- Low: a small spacing inconsistency has little effect.

KEY IDEA **Prioritise issues by their impact on users.**

Write a useful finding and recommendation

A complete finding

- Location → observed issue → user impact → specific recommendation.

Worked example

- “The homepage hides catalogue search below large banners.
- Students may miss it.
- Move search near the page heading.”

KEY IDEA **Precise recommendations are easier to implement and review.**

Library case: improve catalogue discovery

Library task

- Find the catalogue search, a borrowing period or the library’s opening hours.

Likely findings

- An unclear OPAC abbreviation
- an inconspicuous search field
- poor readability on a phone.

KEY IDEA **Use service-specific tasks rather than abstract design opinions.**

Records case: improve public request guidance

Records-centre task

- Find eligibility and steps for requesting a public information document.

Likely findings

- Internal office codes, missing contact steps, or an
- interface that suggests restricted records are publicly available.

KEY IDEA **Do not publish confidential records while demonstrating an interface.**

Live comparison laboratory

Compare examples

- Select Library or Records Centre, then inspect
- the “Needs improvement” and “Improved” examples.

Record observations

- Look for unclear navigation, weak contrast, hidden main tasks and confusing content.

KEY IDEA **Explain why each change helps a visitor.**

Assignment 9: three findings

Your assignment

- Choose one fictional sample website.
- Identify three issues affecting usability.

What to prepare

- Write the issue, its effect on visitors and one specific improvement for each
- one page is enough.

KEY IDEA **No coding is required for this assignment.**

Self-check and key takeaways

Review yourself

- Try eight shuffled questions.
- After submission, review the score and explanations for errors.

Key ideas

- User goals, clear information, inclusive access,
- evidence-based observations and actionable improvements.

KEY IDEA **A visually appealing website is not necessarily a usable one.**

Further reading and next steps

Read further

- W3C WAI: WCAG at a Glance and Easy Checks provide helpful starting points.

Next: JavaScript

- Learn how simple scripts create interactions, change page
- content and provide immediate responses to actions.

KEY IDEA **Continue practising by evaluating familiar information-service webpages.**